

Country Profile: Costa Rica

Nation-Building Policies Dataset

- Number of groups in country: 3
- Plurality religion: Roman Catholicism
- Official language: Spanish
- Official religion: Roman Catholicism
- Core group: Whites/Mestizos

Historical Background

Costa Rica gained full independence upon its separation from the Central American Federation in 1847.¹ Bordering Nicaragua to the north and Panama to the South, and flanked by the Caribbean Sea and the Pacific Ocean, the state has maintained stable territorial boundaries since. Internal conflicts in the beginning of the 20th century led to brief periods of military rule. In 1948, a standing army was abolished and democracy was reinstated to be sustained throughout the second half of the century.

Groups

- **Whites/Mestizos**, descendants of European colonial settlers, form a racialized group covering approximately 84% of the Costa Rican population and the core group of the state, given their traditional dominance rooted in colonial history.² They speak Spanish as their native language. Most adhere to Roman Catholicism, which remains the country's majority religion.³
- **Indigenous Peoples** are a nested minority racialized group comprising around 2% of the population. The largest communities are the **Bribri**, **Cabécar**, and **Guaymí**,⁴ who reside mostly in remote jungle areas, especially along the Panamanian border.⁵ Six Indigenous languages have survived to date,⁶ including those of the

¹ Rankin, 2012.

² Bormann et al., 2017.

³ Rankin, 2012.

⁴ Bormann et al., 2017; Putnam, 1999.

⁵ Minority Rights, 2024.

⁶ Minority Rights, 2024.

Bribri, Cabécar, and Guaymí. The former two speak languages bearing their group names, while the latter speak Ngäbere.⁷ Although the majority follow Roman Catholicism—a legacy of colonial-era conversion—many also adhere to other Christian denominations, including various forms of Protestantism.⁸

- **Afro-Costa Ricans** are a minority racialized group in Costa Rica. Their presence dates back to the 16th century and increased due to more recent waves e.g., immigration of Afro-Caribbean workers in the late 19th century.⁹ Today, they make up around 8% of the population, living mostly in small communities along the Caribbean coast, particularly in the province of Limón.¹⁰ Their language of shared identity, Southwestern Caribbean English Creole, is now moribund as most Afro-Costa Ricans now speak Spanish.¹¹ The group is predominantly Christian, with the plurality adhering to Roman Catholicism.¹²

State Profile

Official Language

The reinstated 1917 Constitution of Costa Rica, which followed the earlier 1871 version, did not establish any official language. Similarly, the initial draft of the 1949 Constitution lacked provisions concerning an official language. It was not until the 1975 constitutional amendment that Spanish was formally established as such by Article 76. In 1999, this article was further expanded to include a commitment to protect Indigenous languages, stating that “the State will ensure the maintenance and cultivation of national Indigenous languages.”¹³

Official Religion

Roman Catholicism was officially declared the state religion of Costa Rica by Article 51 of the 1871 Constitution, stating that “[t]he Catholic, Apostolic and Roman Religion is the religion of the Republic.”¹⁴ This designation was preserved in the 1949 Constitution and

⁷ Ethnologue, 2025.

⁸ Williams, 1989; Rankin, 2012.

⁹ Williams, 1989; Rankin, 2012.

¹⁰ Minority Rights, 2024; Bormann et al., 2017.

¹¹ Ethnologue, 2025; Herzfeld, 2003.

¹² Williams, 2010; Putnam, 1999.

¹³ Constitution of Costa Rica, 1949.

¹⁴ Political Constitution of Costa Rica, 1871.

reaffirmed through subsequent amendments in Article 75, which hold that “[t]he Roman, Catholic, Apostolic Religion is that of the State.”¹⁵

Education Policies

Costa Rica’s education system is structured into three main levels: preschool, primary, and secondary education, with both preschool and primary education being mandatory. Primary education lasts six years. The first year of secondary education is general, after which students choose between professional and technical tracks for the next four years.

Private schools face no restrictions on operating in Costa Rica but are required to impart at least half of their classes in Spanish.¹⁶

Costa Rica adopted **affirmative action** policies in education in favor of Indigenous Peoples. In 1989, the creation of the Rural Education Division (DER) at the National University marked the beginning of targeted teacher training programs for individuals from low-income and remote Indigenous communities. This initiative offered bachelor’s degrees in education with an emphasis on rural teaching and included differentiated admission processes.¹⁷ In 2006, the Interuniversity Coordination Team with Indigenous Peoples (CONARE) was established to coordinate efforts across state universities to implement differentiated admission procedures, including quotas for Indigenous peoples.¹⁸

Language Education Policies

Spanish is the exclusive language of instruction. In 1997, the Higher Council of Education approved the Educational Contextualization Processes for Indigenous Schools. This marked the beginning of a dedicated state policy recognizing and supporting the use of Indigenous languages in education, such as **Bribri**, **Cabécar**, and **Ngäbere**. These reforms introduced structured components for teaching Indigenous mother tongues, local culture, and environmental education in primary and secondary school curricula.¹⁹

Southwestern Caribbean English Creole has received no formal support in the education system. Secondary sources affirm that Creole has never been used in public

¹⁵ Constitution of Costa Rica, 1949.

¹⁶ Costa Rica, 1957.

¹⁷ Carvajal et al., 2017.

¹⁸ Carvajal et al., 2017.

¹⁹ Guevara-Viquez et al., 2015.

schooling; past efforts to increase its use, such as the 1974 proposal to teach English in Limón schools, have ultimately been sidelined in favor of Spanish.²⁰

Religious Education Policies

Religious instruction in Costa Rican public schools has been governed by the 1944 Educational Code, which mandates two hours of Catholic religious education per week in all primary schools, unless parents submit a written request for exemption.²¹ During the 1990s the optional nature of religious education become more fully institutionalized. Parents could choose to opt their children out of the 80-minute weekly sessions without a request for exemption.²²

Constitutions and Laws

The 1871 Constitution, reinstated in 1919 and in force until 1948, did not include any specific references to minority groups and refrained from establishing an official language. While it recognized Roman Catholicism as state religion, its Article 51 also guaranteed universal religious freedom.²³ The 1949 Constitution, along with subsequent amendments, retained these core principles regarding religious liberty and the absence of explicit minority rights provisions. Spanish received its current status as the official language through constitutional amendment in 1975. In 2011, an amendment to Article 1 redefined Costa Rica as “a democratic, free, independent, multiethnic, and multicultural Republic.”²⁴

Citizenship Laws

Costa Rica’s citizenship policy is grounded in a broad application of *jus soli*. As first constitutionally anchored in Article 13 of the 1949 Constitution, citizenship is granted at birth to children born on Costa Rican soil, regardless of their parents’ nationality.

The naturalization process distinguishes between applicants based on historical and regional ties. As introduced by the 1949 Constitution, nationals of Central American countries, Spain, and other Ibero-American states benefit from a reduced residency

²⁰ Vásquez, 2021, 41.

²¹ Costa Rica, 1944, Art. 210.

²² Wahab, 1993.

²³ Political Constitution of Costa Rica, 1871.

²⁴ Constitution of Costa Rica, 1949.

requirement of five years, while other foreign nationals must reside in Costa Rica for at least seven years to be eligible for naturalization.²⁵

National Anthem(s)

The national anthem of Costa Rica combines themes of patriotic devotion and peace, but also defensiveness. Its melody predates the official lyrics and had been in use with various texts until a public contest in 1900 selected the words penned by José María Zeledón Brenes. Although both the music and lyrics were commonly used for decades, they were not formally declared the national anthem until the adoption of the 1949 Constitution. The anthem highlights Costa Rica's identity as a peaceful and loving nation ("oh gentle land" and "oh mother of love"). One of its key verses reflects a readiness for defense, declaring that the people would transform even simple tools into weapons should the nation's glory be threatened.

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²⁵ Constitution of Costa Rica, 1949, Article 14.

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